

Concept tags for work in Week 9: reflection-in-action, iteration at scale, technology as teammate, audience as hero, useful friction, body of work

This was the final week I would get to work on iterating my design and prepare my final presentation. I have been struggling with the back and forth of the iteration process I've been having to do with Claude Code. In V2, I struggled to get Claude to understand what I wanted in my design, it kept creating its own art or using unaesthetic colors and fonts that I simply did not want. Even when feeding my Canva designs and stating what I wanted Claude to do, it would often go in its own direction.

This is when I decided to engage with Schön's "Reflection-in-Action" theory discussed in the slides for this week. It had been something that I was already doing, using Claude as a sounding board and going back and forth between ideas. I set the overall design difficulties aside and decided to work on what interactive features would be most successful for my purposes and for this project. I worked with Claude to add the sidebar and navigation feature I thought about while working on V2 and implemented the upload feature and procedure for users to upload their work and what that process would look like for them. These few days iterating just the features of the web app with Claude were great for my overall progress. I realized that I didn't have to perfect what the website was going to look like just yet, that was an aspect that could take a backseat while I worked on the websites' function. This is when I went back to the original short interview I conducted while working on V1 and sought out some opinions from other Dartmouth students (user testers for the community I would want this website to work for). This is where I looked for what elements would help users and make the website easy and effective.

Then I could start on my final iteration for V3. While I don't think the site is perfect, and I even added some features since presenting in front of the class (see "Week 10" tab), I was able to improve on my design from V2 instead of settling for something that did not meet my standards or fit my idea of what my website should be. Once I got the features down, I decided to turn to social media and YouTube videos to figure out how to design better using Claude. This is what drove me to hearing from some very insightful creators who helped me create a prompt that would get Claude to finally understand what I wanted the site to look like. This is when I reached a point that I was happy with and even pushed me to present my design at Technigala this year, something I've never done before.

This essentially sums up how I, and my approach to design, has changed over this course. These design challenges were filled with things I had never done before. Yet, as I have seen throughout this class, my confidence in designing has grown considerably. This

course has pushed me to run through the design process, from ideation to creation, without giving me the time to second guess myself or stray from my first few original ideas. This has given me the confidence to run with the first idea that strikes my interest and aligns with my passions and I think this has allowed me to create better projects overall. As I have said before, I don't think this project, or I, am finished. Even now that the course is over, I can already see where V4 would begin. But, as I said in my midterm reflection, I believe "Good design is unfinished," and DIPs has proven that to be true. This project is better for every "round of friction," every difficulty, and every failed prompt. I started this course thinking that "good design" required time, experience, exhaustive research, and certainty. I leave it knowing now that, while these help, what "good design" actually requires is a willingness to start, a discipline to listen and iterate, and the humility to let things that aren't working go.